

This approach turns AI testing into an enterprise-ready process rather than a research exercise,” says Gaurav Gupta, Managing Partner at Decimal Point Analytics. Typically, such time-bound pilots run for 8–12 weeks, with clearly defined performance indicators around accuracy, cost savings, or productivity. This time frame balances speed with compliance.

“Pilots that succeed usually show clear economic value within 90 days of inception,” says Apoorva Rangan Sharma, Co-Founder & MD of Venture Catalysts. According to him, pilots that improve operations by 15% or more—such as reducing costs, cutting downtime, or increasing efficiency—often lead customers to sign paid contracts, moving from testing to officially buying or using the solution. Over 60% of such pilots convert, while the weaker ones rarely scale up.

Rather than chasing headline pilots, Qure.AI, a health tech start-up, employs AI for medical imaging diagnostics, prioritising practical, repeatable out-

had about 30% lower attrition than those relying only on cash. Teams with stable and great core engineers tend to release products nearly twice as fast,” says Sharma.

According to Piyush Goel, the CEO and Founder of Beyond Key, the company has committed dedicated resources to advanced certifications and employee innovation labs to retain the best minds. Flexibility at work, professional instructor-led programmes, and interaction with clients from across the world add to employee satisfaction.

SECURING IP FOR SOVEREIGN DATA

Another core challenge is enabling collaboration across teams, partners, and institutions without compromising data sovereignty, intellectual property (IP) protection or regulatory compliance. This risk is amplified where datasets and models are highly sensitive and often subject to strict governance requirements.

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comes that matter to hospitals, such as faster report turnaround times, improved diagnostic consistency, and smoother workflows.

SUSTAINABLE TEAMS

Another big challenge is hiring. According to a report by Teamlease Digital, for every 10 Generative AI job openings in India, only one qualified engineer is available. The report says the AI skill gap could widen to 53% by 2026.

“Only a tiny fraction (of India’s engineers) is trained in areas like advanced materials, chip design, and optics, and many of the best migrate to the US or Europe where funding, peers, and research timelines are more attractive,” says Sunil Gupta, Co-founder, CEO & MD, Yotta Data Services.

Deep-tech start-ups struggle the most with retaining talent like senior engineers after product validation. “Across our portfolio, companies offering employee stock ownership and clear technical road maps

The Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) framework requires organisations to use personal data only for specific, approved purposes and remain fully accountable for how that data is handled. This makes traditional approaches like centralised data sharing or federated access less effective. While these models make collaboration easier, they struggle to properly manage user consent, enforce purpose limits, control cross-border data access, maintain clear audit trails, and protect sensitive personal data under the DPDP rules.

“Founders mitigate this by patent-first engineering and defensive publications before pilots. They file Indian patents through TIFAC-KIRAN or incubator support, followed by PCT (patent cooperation treaty) if needed. For data, companies use anonymisation, DPDP-aligned consent layers, and on-device processing to reduce compliance overhead,” says Bhaskar Majumdar, Managing Partner, Unicorn India Ventures.

To further grow the product idea via experimen-